INDIA PICTURE



Meena Kumari

Caught in a candid mood, Lata Mangeshkar once said that singing for Meena Kumari was among the most satisfying experiences of her career. No actress before, or after, matched her voice on screen with as much feeling, the legendary songstress revealed. You can see it in the eternally exquisite '*Ajeeb dastan hai yeh*'– Meena Kumari pours her passion and pain into song, her words travelling, while she sits demurely still in a corner. Perhaps the 'Tragedy Queen' of Hindi cinema mined her real-life pathos for her roles. It resulted in runaway hits like *Baiju Bawra* and *Parineeta* and celluloid classics like *Sahib Bibi Aur Ghulam* and *Pakeezah*–films that would be nothing without the compelling beauty, the melancholy, the sheer drama of Meena Kumari. Her life may have been brutally cut short, but Meena Kumari remains an acting lodestar.



INDIA PICTURE

Rekha

The Garbo-esque mystique often distracts from her consummate artistry, a feel for layered, complex women that's yielded a canon of pitch-perfect performances (*Ghar*, 1978; *Khoobsurat*, 1980; *Utsav*, 1984) beyond the marquee ones. The legend of Rekha as the sacrificing, jilted lover with husky voice and melancholic eyes, blending reel and real, found its acme in the courtesan of *Umrao Jaan* (1981), under whose irresistible *adaa* and guile hides a heart fragile from repeated betrayal. Seldom has pain looked so beautiful. An immersive, lived-in performance...a role she was born to play.